to Murad in 1580. It was a complicated calculation to appoint powerful courtiers who nonetheless would never challenge Akbar's own position during his lifetime. And though they were powerful, the Ataka clan's loyalty to Akbar had never been questioned. The princes would remain at court under the vigilant eye of their father and were not sent out as governors to develop dangerous and powerful alliances. When Salim was thirteen, Abdur Rahim was appointed as his ataliq and this young man, fostered and saved by Akbar after the terrible murder of his own father, would always show an unshakeable allegiance to the Padshah who had given him the title 'farzand', or 'son'. He was, nonetheless, an accomplished courtier and an excellent choice to teach the young prince the workings of the empire. He was fluent in Arabic, Persian, Turki, and Hindi and was 'famed as a consummate gatherer of rumour, gossip, news and intelligence'. A few years previously, at the age of fourteen, Abdur Rahim had composed a work of astrology called the *Kheta Koutukam*, in a mix of Persian and Sanskrit, confidently stating that 'many of my predecessors composed works in a mixed language—Sanskrit and Persian'. One of these literary predecessors would have been Amir Khusro, whose illustrated work, *Duval Rani va Khizr Khan*, was in the collection of his stepmother, Salima Sultan Begum.

While his children were still very young, Akbar, besides keeping a close watch on their upbringing and education, was a loving and doting father. Jahangir would write that 'after my birth they gave me the name of Sultan Salim but I never heard my father, either drunk or sober, call me Muhammad Salim or Sultan Salim. He always called me Shaikhu Baba', in a tender reminder of the shaikh after whom he was named. Murad was similarly always called Pahari, because he was born on the hilly heights of Fatehpur Sikri. From their pedestrian childhood ailments, like the coughs he treated with alcohol mixed in a little rose water, to guarding them against future rebellions by appointing men who would be 'protectors for his children from the malice of his life-long enemies', Akbar's vigilance was constant. Salim was also sent to the madrasa of the sadr, Shaikh Abd un-Nabi, where he learnt the teachings of the Persian Sufi mystic, Maulana Jami. About the princesses Monserrate added that '[Akbar] gives very great care and attention to the education of the princesses, who are kept rigorously secluded from the sight of men. They are taught to read and write, and are trained in other ways, by matrons.'